

CASE STUDY • FOUNDER-LED CRM

The Baton That Keeps Dropping.

How we discovered why founders lose 60–80% of warm leads —
and built Relay to fix it without asking them to change a thing.



PERSONA: The Founder-Seller's Hurdles



Attharv

Role: Founder & Solo Seller (Kodo Labs, Seed Stage)

Reality: 8–12 Context Switches Daily

Tools: Disjointed (Notion, Sheets, Memory)

Mindset: "It's in my head... until it's not."

ATTHARV'S DAY

7:30am:
Juggling Emails
(Prospects)



9:00am:
Call
(No Notes)



12:00pm:
WhatsApp
(Pricing)



2:00pm:
Investor Q&A
(No Pipeline Data)



4:30pm:
"Log Later"
("Good call.")



7:30am:
Juggling Emails
(Prospects)

9:00am:
Call
(No Notes)

10:30am:
Product Fire
(Bug) [Large
fumbled]

12:00pm:
WhatsApp
(Pricing)

2:00pm:
Investor Q&A
(No Pipeline Data)

desk, baton
dropped into a
crack in the track]

Goal: Close deals & build **context** for handoff.

Meet the Founder-Seller

THE REALITY



50–150

live conversations at once



4–6

channels simultaneously



8–12

context switches daily



Notion / Sheets or
memory — no real CRM



60–80%

of warm leads never get a follow-up

\$1.8M

left on the table per founder/year

"I admittedly ran a pretty messy sales process. I was moving so quickly that process was not top of mind."

— **Alexa Grabell**, Founder of Pocus

12 Pain Points · 3 Failure Phases

Phase 01

Founder Selling Alone

0–5 employees



- Follow-up failure (60–80% gap)
- Manual CRM entry friction
- Conversation context loss
- Context-switching overload
- No documented sales process
- Channel fragmentation
- Phantom pipeline

60–80%
warm leads lost

Phase 02

First Sales Hire Joins

5–10 employees



- First hire inherits empty CRM
- Founder knowledge locked in head

91%
miss quota in Y1

68% leave within 18 months
Avg cost per failed hire: \$60–80K

Phase 03

Small Team Selling

10–20 employees



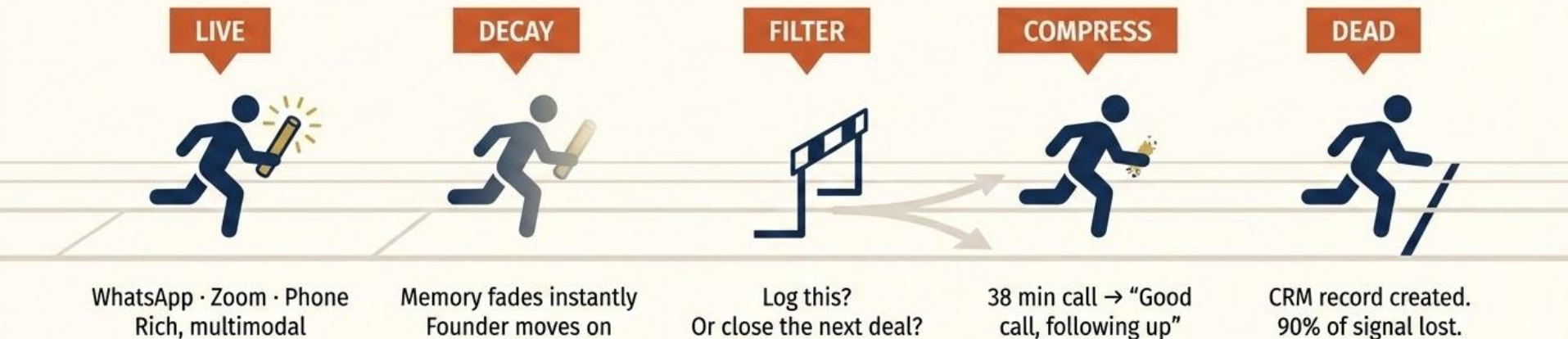
- Duplicate outreach to same prospect
- No clear lead ownership
- Different data standards per rep

49%
of conflicts from ego clashes

"Why did two of you email me?"

Why Conversation Data Dies

The root cause isn't forgetfulness. It's **context-switching overload**.



ROOT CAUSE



CRM sits after the conversation. By the time a founder opens it, tone · commitment · intent is already gone. Founders juggle 8–12 roles/day. CRM logging always loses to the next deal. **The consequence is delayed — the lead dies silently 3 weeks later.**

CHANNEL BLINDNESS

CRMs see the coldest channels. Blind to where deals actually happen.

WARMEST CHANNELS (80% of Deals)



WhatsApp



LinkedIn DMs



Phone Calls

Warmth: Very High / High

Access: None

- Conversations are invisible to CRM.

PARTIAL ACCESS



Zoom / Meet

Warmth: High

Access: Partial

- Requires manual steps or bot setup.

COLDEST CHANNELS (20% of Deals)



Gmail / Outlook



Calendar

Warmth: Medium / Low

Access: Full

- Fully trackable, but lowest trust.

Your CRM only sees 20% of the picture.

WHY NOW

The Timing Has Never Been Better

75%

of new tech startups are
Solo or 2-person founding
teams (2024)



Founder-Led Sales is the New Norm.

FOUR CONVERGING TAILWINDS



1 Leaner for Longer

AI enables smaller teams;
founders carry sales deeper.



2 Founder-Led Default

VCs coach personal selling;
82% rely on referrals.

3

Hires Fail Without Context

91% miss quota due to
poor context transfer.



4

Market Gap

No tool exists for 0-20
person founder-led sales.

Two obvious fixes. Both wrong.

PATH A: Record Everything

- ✓ Captures Context
- ✓ AI Extracts Data

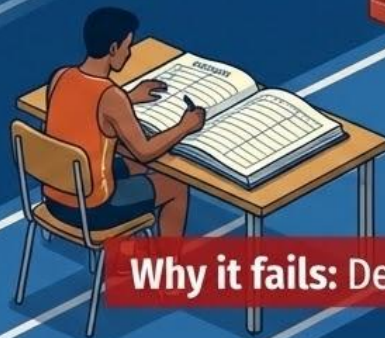


Why it fails: High Friction & Legal Risk



PATH B: Ask for Input

- ✓ Founder Provides Context
- ✓ AI Cleans Data



Why it fails: Demands New Behavior



BOTH PATHS FAIL: They demand new behavior at the exact moment the founder is least likely to act.

What if we stopped asking?

Don't ask founders to do something new. **Read what they're already doing.**



No new behavior. Almost zero behavior tax

The baton passes cleanly.

Phase 1:
Founder alone



✗ Drops batons (deals)
✗ Inherits empty CRM

Phase 2:
First hire joins



✗ Drops batons (deals)
✗ Inherits empty CRM

Phase 3:
Team selling



Catches every
dropped deal



Inherits warm
context



Shared source
of truth

“The CRM that does not ask you to log anything.”

TRANSITIONING TO THE SOLUTION

INTRODUCING THE RELAY PROTOTYPE



From manual effort to automated context.

THANK YOU

Ready to automate your context?



relay.app